

Artist Not Found

Neither a memoir nor a manifesto

Raghava KK

For Aadya, Jaya, Anaga, and Rudra—

I put your names in reverse.

Because the youngest is often the wisest.

Because order is boring.

Because I can.

This book isn't for children.

But somehow, it's all about you.

You're the reason I ever wanted to be real.

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Part One

Chapter I

Letter: If One Day You Wonder Who I Was

TO MY CHILDREN,

If you ever find this-

maybe years from now,

maybe after you've already made your own mistakes-

I want to tell you a few things I never knew how to say when you were small

and I was trying to hold everything together.

I was not always the man you needed.

I know that.

There were times you looked at me

and I was already elsewhere-in my head, on a plane, in a painting.

There were weekends I showed up with too much excitement

and weekdays I disappeared into exhaustion.

There were moments I held your hand and still felt far away.

It's not because I didn't love you.

It's because I didn't know how to love myself.

And I was afraid-afraid that if you saw all of me,

you'd inherit the parts I hadn't made peace with.

But I want you to know this:

You saved me.

Not in the grand, cinematic way.

But in the daily, quiet way.

With your questions.

Your drawings.

Your ridiculous, beautiful truths.

You reminded me what it means to be seen without performing.

To be asked, "Appa, are you okay?" and not need to lie.

And if one day you wonder who I really was-

not the version in the interviews,

not the one painted in headlines or exhibitions-

just the man underneath-

Know this:

I was someone trying.

Trying to heal without a map.

Trying to break cycles I didn't fully understand.

Trying to give you the softness I was once punished for.

You are not the result of my failures.

You are the reason I kept choosing truth, even when it hurt.

And I hope, wherever you are now,

you know you were loved-not for your brilliance or your beauty-

but for your being.

That was always enough.

Love,

Appa

Chapter 2

Monkey Brain – The Riot Inside

THERE'S a riot in my skull.

Not a protest. Not a polite disagreement of thoughts.

The monkey in my head doesn't meditate.

It's not the wise kind sitting under a Bodhi tree.

It's a feral one-teeth bared, eyes wide, heart pounding.

It's swinging from dopamine to doom in under five seconds,

smashing every button labeled WHAT IF and REMEMBER THAT
HUMILIATING THING FROM 2009?

I don't "have thoughts."

I get *ambushed* by them.

They clamor like locusts.

One thought starts a fire. Another throws gasoline.

And another tells me, calmly, that everyone I love is about to leave.

No reason. Just a *feeling*.

Just a *gut churn* I've learned not to ignore.

Anxiety?

It's not butterflies. It's vultures.

Circling.

Waiting for the moment I let my guard down.

I walk into a room: I don't see people.

I see danger. Judgment. Rejection.

I play out the entire script of how I'll be misunderstood before I even say
hello.

And then I go home and *replay* everything I did say,

frame by frame,

until I convince myself I ruined it.

I can't focus: the monkey is screaming.

I can't rest: the monkey is scheming.

I can't breathe right. Somewhere in the back of my mind

I am preparing for a disaster that hasn't happened yet-

but *will*.

Trying to keep the monkey from breaking into my chest

and making a home behind my ribs.

Some nights it wins.

Some mornings I wake up with its claws already in my throat.

And nobody sees it.

Because it's invisible.

Because I've learned to smile while being eaten alive from the inside out.

But I know.

I fucking *know*.

And now, so do you.

Chapter 3

The Loop

THERE'S a rhythm to my life.

It looks like momentum, but it's a loop.

Starts with fire-always fire.

An idea so alive it shakes me.

I lose sleep. I lose track of time. I pour everything into it. This time I'll finally become whole through the act of doing.

Then comes the flood.

Hyperfocus is now compulsion.

The idea isn't a joy anymore-it's a boulder I have to push across the finish line.

People start expecting things. I start resenting them.

I disappear.

Phone off. Inbox radioactive.

Then the shame.

The slow, sour taste of having ghosted the very thing I claimed to love.

I call it burnout, but really?

it's avoidance dressed up as fatigue.

Then the silence.

Everything feels dull, stupid, beneath me.

I question my identity, my worth, whether I've ever truly created anything real.

Until one day, another idea knocks.

And I open the door like I wasn't just in ruins.

Start again.

This time will be different.

It won't.

Because I've built my life around intensity, not sustainability.

Around arrival, not maintenance.

Around the drama of restarting-

not the humility of staying.

This is the loop.

And no, I haven't broken it.

I just know its name now.

Sometimes that's enough to slow it down.

Sometimes it isn't.

You only know the *clever survivor*-

And I don't know how to bring him back.

Chapter 4

I Grieve the Versions of Me You Never Met

EVERY TIME SOMEONE LOVES ME,

they love the version that arrived *after*.

After the loss. After the reinvention. After the mask.

But I grieve the ones they never knew.

The tender, ridiculous selves

I strangled to become legible.

I want to scream:

“I was softer once! I used to dance when no one asked me to!

I used to believe love didn't have to hurt!”

But you weren't there.

You can't mourn the boy who broke for beauty.

Part Two

Chapter 5
Before I Paint
—a reminder to myself

I'M NOT HERE to prove.

I'm not here to please.

I'm not here to make something beautiful.

I'm here to *find something true*.

Today, I give myself permission to mess up.

To overwork, and underthink.

To let the brush move before the meaning arrives.

To ruin a canvas if it means I stayed honest.

I will not begin with a concept.

I will begin with a breath.

If the fear shows up-welcome it.

But don't hand it the brush.

If the old tricks come-see them.

But don't let them drive.

I don't need to rehearse what I've already mastered.

I need to touch what I haven't dared to yet.

I am not performing.

I am not explaining.

I am not selling.

I am **listening**.

To the color.

To the texture.

To the ache that has no words yet.

There is no right move.

There is only the *next* honest one.

Let the painting surprise me.

Let it resist coherence.

Let it interrupt me.

Now:

Begin.

Chapter 6

When I Face the Canvas, Every Ghost Shows Up

I want to paint like I'm not being
watched, even when I am.

THE MOMENT I stand in front of a blank canvas, the room gets crowded.

Not with people.

With voices.

Will this be beautiful?

Will they like it?

Will they pay for it?

Will they think I've lost it?

I hear the critics before the brush touches the surface.

I feel the heat of performance, even in silence.

I catch myself reaching for my old tricks-

The color I know will seduce.

The gesture that looks wild but isn't risky.

The chaos I can control.

I end up rehearsing.

Not art.

Applause.

That's the first betrayal.

Because I didn't come here to please.

I came here to find something. To lose something. To unlearn.

But when my hand moves, so does my fear.

So does my need to impress the absent gaze.

So does every version of me that sold something too soon, or too safe.

to stop that.

let the canvas be a journal.

But how?

How do I move past the urge to decorate my fear?

Maybe I start by letting the canvas hold my anxiety, not escape it.

Maybe I mark the panic. Name it.

Maybe I let the ugly part stay longer than I usually allow.

Maybe I stop asking "what will this become?";

start asking "what needs to speak today?"

The work doesn't need to resolve.

It needs to reveal.

And maybe the first revelation is this:

That my real art begins where my control ends.

Chapter 7

I Keep Trying to Resolve the Painting So It Can Forgive Me

I HAVE A HABIT I HATE:

I keep trying to make the painting beautiful-
not because it asks me to.

I use beauty like a bandage.

To cover the places I got too honest.

To make the wound look like I design.

There's a moment in every painting-

right after the chaos, right before the breakthrough-

where the pressure starts to whisper:

Fix it. Smooth it. Make it something they'll want to hang.

Betrayal?

Because I rescue it too soon.

Because I want it to be admired.

Worse-because I want *to be admired through it*.

Because what if I leave the painting unresolved?

What if it stays jagged, awkward, exposed?

Would anyone still love it?

Would I?

I've trained my eye to know exactly when the work becomes sellable.

I can feel the shift.

The temptation to wrap it up

with just enough coherence to be legible.

But that's not the artist I want to be.

I don't want to keep painting apologies.

I don't want to make beauty the bribe I offer so people stay.

I want to leave the wound open.

Because maybe the real beauty

is not in the resolution-

but in the refusal to be resolved.

Chapter 8

The One Who Painted Before He Knew What Art Was

THERE WAS A BOY.

He painted without themes.

Without composition.

Without wondering if the color palette would photograph well.

He didn't ask if it was art.

He just wanted to see it outside his body.

He didn't have a brand.

He didn't have collectors.

He hadn't learnt shame yet.

He made a mess because it was *his*.

He ruined paintings and laughed.

He drew naked bodies before anyone told him not to.

He painted rage, joy, longing-without needing a name for any of it.

He wasn't trying to become an artist.

He was trying not to disappear.

And somehow, along the way, I forgot him.

I got good. Too good.

I learned how to hold a brush like a promise.

How to finish.

How to sell.

How to be taken seriously.

But sometimes, when the studio is quiet

and I'm too tired to perform,

he shows up again.

He doesn't care about the buyer/viewer.

He just wants to play.

To push the red into the black until it feels wrong enough to be true.

And. I interrupt him.

I banish him.

I tidy his chaos before anyone sees.

Because I'm scared he'll make something real

and I won't be able to explain it.

I miss the way he listened to the canvas-

I'm trying now.

To give him more space.

And if I'm being honest-

he's the only one who ever made anything worth keeping.

Chapter 9

If I Don't Create, I Start to Rot

I DON'T CREATE for beauty.

I create to survive.

I've tried stillness.

Tried not needing to make something.

Tried letting the moment pass without building a structure around it.

But it never lasts.

There's tension under my skin

that only eases when I'm mid-creation-

when my hands are busy, my mind goes quiet

when I'm pulling something out of nothing.

And then, I build performances out of grief.

I turn longing into landscapes.

Creation is not just how I express.

How I survive my own emotional weather.

It's the one place where no one can find me.

Where I don't have to explain myself

or simplify the contradiction.

Some meditate, some pray.

I build things I don't fully understand

To find out who I am

If I don't create,

I start performing again.

Start eroding.

So no-

this isn't just art.

This is how I don't go numb.

Chapter 10

I Used to Be Popular. Now I Just Feel.. Archived.

THERE WAS a time people knew me.

Not just my name.

My face. My work. My voice.

I was in the rooms.

Not adjacent to them-*in* them.

On the lists. In the press. On the stage.

I was what they called *emerging*

long after I had already emerged.

And I built that without social media.

No reels. No algorithms. No daily engagement.

Just the work.

The shows.

The performances that made people feel something live.

It was a slower kind of fame.

Warmer, maybe.

But it didn't last.

Because now?

Now popularity means something else.

It means visibility you can *measure*.

It means click rates. Metrics. Followers. Feeds.

And I'm not built for that.

I come from a time when *presence* was earned in person.

When a collector felt your energy and decided, *yes, I want this one's madness on my wall*.

Now, they scroll.

And I don't scroll well.

I'm too raw for captions.

Too emotionally unruly to play the game every day.

So the world moved on.

Or maybe it just moved somewhere I'm not fluent.

And I'm left wondering-

Am I outdated?

Am I being forgotten in slow motion?

And here's the worst part-

When I do try to show up in their world,

I feel fake.

Like I'm trying to stay relevant

just long enough to be loved again.

But I don't want to be loved *like this*.

I want to be *felt*.

In full.

Even if that means fading in a world that only rewards the daily urge to be seen.

Chapter II

I Steal From the Internet and Call It Collage, But Sometimes I Just Feel Like a Fraud

I FIND IMAGES ONLINE.

I rip them from context.

I tear them into pieces and make something new.

It's fast. It's instinctive. It's chaotic.

It's also...

Not in the way I was taught art is supposed to be.

I tell myself I'm making meaning.

Reframing. Remixing.

That collage is its own language-

a way of showing how nothing is ever just itself anymore.

But some days, if I'm being honest,

it doesn't feel like "Art".

It feels like theft dressed up as process.

I know others do it, but

I look at artists who start from a blank,

who summon whole worlds from pigment and patience,

and I doubt myself.

Because what I'm doing is fast.

Intuitive. Sloppy, even.

Sometimes I don't know if it's

avoidance in drag.

I want to say: *This is how I see the world-fragmented, nonlinear, stolen
and repurposed.*

But part of me is scared I will call my bluff and say:

No. You just didn't want to draw.

And maybe that me is right.

Maybe I don't. Maybe

Drawing feels too slow for my brain?

My hands don't move the way they used to?

I don't have the discipline I once did?

Maybe I'm just fucking tired.

But still-when it works...

When I layer something broken into something whole?

When a piece clicks in a way I didn't expect.

And I'm ALIVE again.

And it's mine.

And that's enough.

Chapter 12

I Don't Belong Anywhere, and It's Starting to Wear Me Down

I DON'T FIT in the art world.

They want themes. Styles. A clear arc.

I have none.

I make what I feel when I feel it.

Sometimes I paint. Sometimes I code. Sometimes I disappear for months and come back with a new mind.

They want consistency.

I offer combustion.

I don't fit in the startup world either.

They want frameworks. Decks. Scale.

I show up with mischief. With questions no one asked.

They want clarity.

I offer contradiction.

I don't even fit in the rebel worlds-

the offbeat collectives, the alt scenes.

There, you're supposed to perform a kind of cool.

And I'm not cool.

I'm earnest in a way that makes people uncomfortable.

I still believe in beauty. In awe. In softness as a weapon.

That makes me sound naïve in rooms built on cynicism.

So where do I go?

Where do you go when you're too wild for the system

but too rooted for the underground?

Where do you stand

when every world you enter requires you to amputate a piece of yourself
to be understood?

I keep orbiting places

hoping one will let me stay whole.

But none do.

And I'm tired.

I'm tired of explaining.

I'm tired of charming my way into spaces that don't actually want me.

Some days, I wish I could just be one thing.

Clean. Classifiable. Easier to carry.

But I know I'd die that way.

So I stay here, in the exile,

Building a home out of contradictions.

Populating it with ghosts.

And praying someone else out there is doing the same

so we can one day meet in the wild

and recognize each other.

Chapter 13

What Happens When I Don't Stop Myself

WHEN I DON'T STOP myself,

there is no plan.

There is no composition, no theme, no audience in my head taking notes.

Feel it: that pressure behind the ribs that says: **move.**

My hand trembles with permission.

The permission to be messy.

To be obvious.

To be ridiculous.

To ruin it.

And god, sometimes I do ruin it.

I overpaint.

I go too far.

I layer colors that should never sit together.

But then something happens.

I surprise myself.

Not because it's beautiful.

But because it's mine.

Unplanned. Unwanted. Uncontrolled.

But undeniably true.

And sometimes, just past that moment of almost-ugly,
comes a stroke that feels like a revelation.

A tear in the fabric.

A pulse I didn't know was missing.

The painting starts speaking back.

It doesn't ask for applause.

It just *is*.

No scaffolding.

Just the rhythm of presence.

This is what I forget every time I reach for control:

That the work only breathes when I'm willing to stop narrating.

That beauty doesn't arrive through caution-

But surrender.

When I don't stop myself, I don't become a better artist.

I become a braver one.

And that's the artist I want to be remembered as.

The one who stayed

Even after the fear arrived.

Chapter 14

When I Say I'm a Personality Artist, What I Mean Is: I Don't Know How to Be Boring

I'M NOT A TECHNICAL ARTIST.

I'm haven't mastered brushwork, composition or theory.

And I've made peace with that.

Sort of.

What I am is *felt*.

People buy my work because they feel me in it.

Because it's loud, alive and full of contradictions they recognize but can't name.

I'm not selling technique. I'm selling essence.

And some days, that makes me proud.

I tell myself I'm a personality artist.

That my life *is* the art.

That the chaos, the projects, the shifts, the shifts *after* the shifts-
they're all part of the same living canvas.

But, sometimes I wonder if that's just branding.

A clever way to hide the fact that I can't commit to one thing long
enough to become a master.

That I'm terrified of being boring.

That I've built an entire creative identity around not being pinned
down,

because deep down I'm scared of what the silence after focus may
reveal.

I envy artists who paint the same subject for twenty years.

Not because I want that life-God no.

But because they seem to know something I don't.

Something about stillness. About depth.

I keep shifting forms and themes-

not out of restlessness, but because I'm scared I'll be found out.

Scared that if I stop performing the "unexpected,"

they'll realize I'm just another artist who never quite landed.

So I stay in motion.

Not for the art.

Not even for them.

But because if I keep changing, I never have to prove I'm enough by
staying the same.

Part Three

Chapter 15

I Use Love to Escape the Mirror

I FALL for people just to avoid falling into myself.

If you're interesting enough,

if your chaos is loud enough,

if your dreams are beautiful enough-

I don't have to look at my own reflection.

I pour into you to ignore the ache in me.

I chase your wounds because mine are too familiar.

You call it devotion.

I call it distraction.

And by the time I realize it,

I've already written you into a story

that was never yours to carry.

Chapter 16

I Only Let You Close If You Don't Ask for Closeness

I WRITE about intimacy like I invented it.

But when it shows up-messy, real, persistent-I panic.

Because closeness means *mirrors*.

It means they might see the parts I'm still ashamed of.

So I let them admire me.

Even touch me.

But only if they don't *need* me.

Need is dangerous.

Need feels like obligation in disguise.

And I've spent a lifetime trying to love without being trapped by it.

I'll let you orbit me forever.

As long as you don't try to land.

Chapter 17

I Want to Be Held. But I Built Myself to Be Unholdable.

I WANT someone to see through me-

to all the tangled, contradictory, inconvenient truths-

and *still* say, "I choose this."

But I've made it hard.

My intelligence is a fortress.

My charm, a labyrinth.

My emotions a language with no translation guide.

I want to be held, yes.

But I've also spent years building armor that whispers:

Don't come close.

Because if you touch what actually hurts-

I might fall apart.

And if I fall apart, I don't know who I'll be when I stand back up.

So I stay almost reachable.

Almost honest.

And wonder why no one ever fully arrives.

Chapter 18

I Show My Want to the Wrong Person on Purpose

EVERY NOW AND THEN,

I let it slip.

The want.

I show it.

Deliberately.

To someone I know *won't* want me back.

Not because I'm broken.

Because I want to *feel the ache untouched*.

To stand in front of someone who will *not return it*,

and let that unreturned fire *lick at me*-slow and clean.

There's something sacred in offering your hunger

to someone who smiles kindly and looks away.

Not cruelty.

Not confusion.

Distance.

The safest kind.

They'll just let me glow there-

awkward, brave, too open-

and say something like,

“Oh.”

And I'll smile.

And I'll walk away with my heart thrumming like I just survived something sacred.

Because I did.

You don't understand:

There's a clarity that comes from being *seen and not taken*.

A heat that just simmers.

Unresolved.

Holy.

Chapter 19

I Want to Be Chosen Without Ever Asking

I WON'T SAY IT.

I won't text first.

I won't lean in.

I won't confess.

But I will dress like I hope you'll notice.

Linger when I should leave.

I will give you an opening,

just wide enough to wonder

if something might be there.

And if you walk through it,

I will act surprised.

This isn't pride.

It's fear braided with longing.

It's the ache of being seen *without auditioning*.

If you choose me,

it means I didn't have to betray my silence.

It means I was enough *in my stillness*.

But if you miss the opening,

mistake my careful distance for disinterest-

I will nod. Smile. Swallow it whole.

And later, alone,

I'll wait to be chosen

from a place no one else can see.

Chapter 20

I Want to Watch Without Entering

SOMETIMES I FIND myself in the room.

Not part of it, but nearby.

There are hands.

Whispers.

Breath moving in tight circles between people who are brave enough to break the seal.

And I sit in the corner-

still, unlit, *uninvited on purpose*.

Not because I'm afraid.

Because *entering ruins it*.

I want to *listen to skin*.

I want to be near the ache

without having to *be the ache*.

I study the rhythms,

the gasps,

the soft instructions passed between mouths.

And while they unravel each other,

I stay whole.

Because the part of me that burns

also guards the flame.

Sometimes, I am the floor.

Sometimes, the air.

Sometimes, the mirror.

But never the mouth.

Never the thrust.

Chapter 21

The Edge of the Screen

THERE'S a glow in the dark.

Something that hums when the world gets quiet,
when loneliness grows louder than the clock.

You already know.

It lives in the tension between boredom and craving,
in that space where impulse pretends to be choice.

It's not about sex.

Not really.

It's about control.

About intimacy

on demand,

without the risk of being seen.

There's a version of myself that only exists in the flicker of a screen.

He doesn't flinch.

He doesn't get rejected.

He doesn't have to perform tenderness, only hunger.

And the hunger is easy.

It doesn't need to be held afterward.

But afterward always comes.

And it's quiet.

Not the good kind.

A subtle erosion-

not enough to collapse me,

just enough to blur something essential.

A softness. A curiosity.

A patience I used to have for real people,

for the ache of real connection.

And I start to forget the difference

between touch and transaction.

Between turn-on and tuning out.

Between release and retreat.

It's not guilt I carry.

It's the dull knowing

That what was once taboo

has become *routine*,

what was once private

has become *predictable*.

I'm not moralizing.

I'm just standing at the edge of the screen,

asking myself quietly:

When did this stop being a doorway-

and become a cage?

Chapter 22

The Window

I'M NOT DRESSED for beauty.

Not dressed at all, really.

Old shirt. Bare thighs. Hair in no shape.

I'm not posing.

I'm pouring tea.

Looking out the window.

Inside a moment too quiet for vanity.

But I know you're watching.

Not in a devouring way.

Not in a claiming way.

Just... present.

Your gaze doesn't ask for anything.

Doesn't shape- just lands.

And something in my hips softens.

Something in my chest opens.

Not to be taken.

Just to be *seen*.

I don't look back.

If I did, the spell would break.

You'd smile. Or speak.

And I'd become *aware of myself again*.

But right now,

I am a body

being noticed

without needing to explain.

And that-

that might be

the most erotic thing I've ever felt.

Chapter 23

Seat 14B

HE's in the window seat.

I'm in the middle.

Someone forgettable sits in the aisle-so I make them unforgettable.

Laugh too easily.

Ask too many questions.

Perform *just enough joy* to make him wonder.

I feel him watching.

Not staring.

Tracking.

Like his body knows something he hasn't admitted to himself yet.

I don't look at him.

Not once.

But I know exactly how he's sitting.

I know the shape of his thigh next to mine.

I know he hasn't moved in seven minutes and that's not comfort-it's *restraint*.

Our arms never touch.

But they want to.

The space between our sleeves is *so loaded it might as well be skin*.

He shifts.

Barely.

And I feel a current pass through my ribs like a warning.

I keep talking to the aisle passenger.

I say something witty.

I laugh.

But everything in me is *pointed left*.

I sip water just to feel my lips do something.

I adjust my tray, hoping the movement will *accidentally* knock against his.

It doesn't.

The attendant passes.

We both reach at once.

My elbow grazes his forearm.

Contact.

Lightning in a gesture so innocent it should be illegal.

He doesn't react.

Neither do I.

That's how I know he felt it.

We land.

We gather our things.

We never speak.

But I can still feel the hum of that moment

pressed into my skin.

Chapter 24

I've Used Love to Escape My Calling

THERE WERE times I fell in love

not because I wanted to,

but because I needed a way out of

who I was becoming.

To distract myself from the art

that was too risky to make.

To delay the change that was too costly to choose.

They became my sabbatical from purpose.

My detour from

what I did not want to face.

I let their chaos drown mine

because it was easier

than answering the question:

What happens if I stop loving others long enough to become who I really am?

Chapter 25

I Want Love to Break Me and Still Stay

I DON'T WANT easy love.

I want the kind that sees every fracture and chooses to stay anyway.

Not as a savior.

Not as a solution.

Just as someone who doesn't flinch at the wreckage.

I want to be known *inconveniently*-

not through poems I choreograph,

but through the ugly silences I can't translate.

I want to be held when I've lost the script.

When my voice shakes. When I smell like failure.

When I'm not making anyone feel inspired.

Chapter 26

What I Hide in Beautiful Sentences

PEOPLE THINK I use language to explain.

I don't.

I use it to *distract you from the pulse under the table*.

You think it's truth.

But it's just

is a performance, of vulnerability,

polished just enough to *conceal the part of me that's throbbing*.

I write like I want to be understood.

But every perfect phrase is a wall.

Every metaphor is a curtain.

I don't want you to see me.

I want you to feel me and never be sure if you're allowed to.

That's where it is.

Not in the act-

in the *delay*.

I craft sentences like rooms with no doors.

And while you're there,

you'll feel *watched*.

You'll feel the soft press of something unnamed

sitting beside you in the silence.

Eros, for me, is never the naked body.

It's the sentence that brushes your inner thigh

without ever breaking eye contact.

It's the comma that pauses long enough

for you to feel the breath behind it.

It's the phrase you reread

not because you didn't understand it-

but because you *felt something rise*

and wanted to feel it again

without admitting that you did.

I don't hide behind language.

I *seduce through it*.

And if you’re reading this,
you’ve already taken off more than you realized.

Part Four

Chapter 27

I Am Most Alone When Everyone Thinks I'm Fine

THERE'S a particular kind of loneliness
that comes when you're constantly visible-
and rarely seen.

I've been surrounded for years.

By collaborators. Collectors. Audiences.

People who quote me back to myself.

People who call me "brilliant," "inspiring," "rare."

And yet-

there are nights I sit in rooms full of admiration

and feel like I'm slowly disappearing.

Because I'm learning,

Admiration isn't intimacy.

Recognition is not resonance.

I've known how to be the centre.

Loud. Captivating.

But who has sat with me in my quieter truths?

The ones I don't say on stage.

The ones that don't photograph well.

The ones that make me feel like a little boy

waiting for someone to sit beside him and not ask him to be anything.

Some of this is my fault.

I've made it hard to reach me.

Hard to stay with me once the brilliance fades.

Hard to love me when I'm not offering light.

I'm trying now

to let fewer people in,

but let them in all the way.

I don't want to be known widely.

I want to be known deeply.

Even if it's only by a few.

Even if it's only by me.

Chapter 28

When I Sound Wise, I'm Usually Hiding Something

PEOPLE SAY I'M ARTICULATE.

They say I make meaning from chaos, that I help others see.

And yes, I do.

But often, my eloquence is camouflage.

It's easier to explain than to feel.

Easier to offer a philosophy than to say:

I'm overwhelmed. I'm scared. I'm spiralling and I don't know where the ground is.

I've spent a lifetime translating the raw into the refined.

Turning confusion into frameworks.

Turning heartbreak into art.

Turning silence into TED talks.

And the world applauded.

They always do when pain arrives well-dressed.

But perhaps:

Real courage isn't articulating the wound-

it's in standing in it

without explaining it away.

Chapter 29

I Can't Tell If I'm Still Performing or Just Existing Now

I'VE SPENT my whole life learning how to hold a room.

It started young-

making teachers laugh so I wouldn't be punished for thinking differently.

Drawing nudes, then cartoons, then attention.

Later it became more polished:

The talks. The stages. The exhibitions.

The curated chaos that made people say "brilliant" - not "human."

Performance became second nature.

And then the other voice.

The critic.

The one who watches me

and whispers, This isn't you.

You're protecting something again.

It's a brutal loop:

I perform to connect.

Then judge myself for not being authentic.

Then try to perform my authenticity.

I've lost track, sometimes,

of whether I'm being honest

or just really good at looking honest. But

There are moments-brief, sacred ones-

where I'm held by someone, or painting alone...

Chapter 30

The Shame That Made Me Famous

I DIDN'T BECOME famous for what I wanted to be seen for.

I was seen for the thing I couldn't fully control.

The provocation. The speed. The spectacle.

They called it genius.

But it was just me trying not to disappear.

I performed my curiosity like a product.

Painted my pain.

Told the truth through metaphors so no one would ask what I was hiding.

And they loved it.

They clapped. They funded. They flew me around the world.

And I smiled-

because I thought if I smiled long enough, the shame might leave my body.

It didn't.

The shame lived underneath the TED stage.

It lived in the hotel room after the show.

It lived in the moment my child said, "Appa, why do you have to go?"

It lived in the painting I overworked until it bled for me.

I'm not here to make sense of it.

I'm here because I'm tired of being seen for the mask I learned to wear.

I'm here to show you what it costs to be applauded for a self that's not fully yours.

And what it feels like to come back, layer by layer.

Chapter 31

When the Spotlight Burned Me

YOU DON'T REALIZE the spotlight is fire until it starts peeling skin.

At first, it just feels warm-like attention, like relevance, like love.

People see you. Want you.

You mistake that for being known.

But the truth is, the spotlight can't hold your whole self.

Only your outline.

Only what's easy to praise.

It doesn't care about the things that kept you up at night.

The resentment in your partner's silence.

The feeling that you're only brilliant if someone else says so.

The first time I felt the burn, I said yes to a talk I should've canceled.

My body was unraveling. My marriage, too.

I stood on stage and gave them my best self-

while my real one was in freefall.

They called it inspiring.

Said I radiated confidence.

Said I had reinvented myself.

But I was just surviving.

That's what performance is: a more elegant kind of drowning.

And the applause didn't save me.

It trapped me.

That's when I knew:

Fame isn't a reward.

It's a mirror so close,

you mistake the reflection for your face.

And shame?

Shame is what you feel when you know the reflection isn't real-

but you keep holding still for the camera anyway.

Chapter 32

Am I Disgusting?

IT'S NOT a question I say out loud.

But it lives under everything.

It's rancid. Constant.

Am I disgusting?

Not just physically-though that's part of it.

I've scanned my face in mirrors, in windows, in other people's eyes,

looking for the flaw they're surely trying not to name.

But it's deeper than that.

It's the fear that something about me

is fundamentally off.

Wrong.

Repelling.

That no matter how kind, clever, generous, or creative I am,
there's a core part of me
that makes people squirm-
even if they smile through it.
It's why compliments don't land.
Why love always feels like a misunderstanding.
Why sex, at times,
has felt like a performance to distract from the truth
that I'm being touched
in spite of what I am.
If your face changes-just slightly-
my stomach drops.
I fill in the blank:
You saw it.
You smelled it.
You know.
I don't even know what "it" is.
But I've felt it my whole life.
And the worst part,
I've built so many layers over it-
that I sometimes forget it's even there.

But it lies in wait.

Quiet,
constant.

Asking the same question:

Am I disgusting?

Chapter 33

PERFORMER

PERFORMER

(pacing)

They still ask for me, you know.

Want me to talk about creativity. Reinvention.

Want to hear how I turned my pain into platforms.

It still works.

WITNESS

(sipping tea, slowly)

Does it?

PERFORMER

Come on. You know the game.

You've watched me play it well.

Even you can't deny that.

WITNESS

(silence)

I watched you walk off stage and cry in hotel bathrooms.

I watched you turn your children into punchlines to survive a 20-minute talk.

You made your truth digestible.

They clapped.

You broke.

PERFORMER

They needed something.

Something they could hold. Something clean.

WITNESS

And you gave it to them.

Even when it meant slicing off the parts of you still learning how to breathe.

PERFORMER

(facing the window)

What do you want from me?

To break down in public? To become forgettable?

WITNESS

No.

I want you to be *honest*.

Let the silence in.

To say “I don’t know” and not rush to fill it with poetry.

PERFORMER

(whispers)

If I stop performing... who’s left?

WITNESS

Someone quieter.

Less certain.

But more whole.

PERFORMER

And what if they don’t want him?

WITNESS

Then maybe it’s time *you* want him.

(long pause)

PERFORMER

You think I’m afraid.

WITNESS

I *know* you are.

You’re terrified the love was for the mask.

That without it, you’ll be invisible.

PERFORMER

(sits)

I don’t know how to be without an audience.

WITNESS

Then start with one person.

Your son.

Your daughter.

Yourself.

PERFORMER

What if I fail?

WITNESS

You will.

And they will love you anyway-if you let them.

Chapter 34

When No One Is Judging Me, I Become the Judge

IT DOESN'T MATTER if the room is empty.

I've internalized the tribunal.

There's always a voice in my head

cataloguing my flaws.

It sounds like logic.

Feels like protection.

But it's shame in a tailored suit.

When someone doesn't like me,

doesn't respond,

doesn't smile-

I don't just notice it.

I *collapse* into it.

The voice rushes in:

You're trying too hard.

You're not as interesting as you think you are.

They saw through you.

Even when I'm alone, it doesn't stop.

I still rehearse failure.

Still pull up a mental record of every moment

I was too much, or not enough.

It's exhausting,

being both the accused

and the prosecution.

I don't know when I became this voice.

Or maybe it became me.

But somewhere along the way,

I decided that if someone was going to judge me,

it might as well be me first.

Chapter 35

Shame Won't Let Me Feel Anything Pure

EVERY TIME I get close to something true-
something tender, raw, *mine*-
shame barges in.

It drags in a file cabinet full of verdicts:

I'm not allowed to feel what I'm feeling.

I start to cry, and the judge inside me says:

Here are ten moments you were dramatic.

Here's why no one should feel sorry for you.

Here's why this is manipulation, not emotion.

I feel proud of something I made-

and shame shows me a version of myself

who wanted praise too badly.

I feel desire-

and it whispers that I'm gross for wanting.

That I'm just performing again.

Every time I try to trust a feeling,

shame turns it into evidence

against me.

So instead of feeling,

I analyze.

I perform emotional fluency

to avoid emotional *intimacy*.

Even with myself.

Because somewhere along the way,

I learned that rawness is dangerous.

That truth is punishable.

That real feeling

is something I have to *deserve*.

And I never do.

Chapter 36

Self-Acceptance vs. Self-Abandonment

THERE'S a fine line between owning who I am and giving up on who I could be.

Some days, I tell myself:

“This is just how I'm wired.”

As if that settles it.

As if the moment I name my wiring, the consequences dissolve.

But naming isn't healing.

It's not a finish line.

It's a flashlight in a cave-useful, but not enough.

Sometimes, I use identity as insulation.

ADHD. Neurodivergent. Sensitive. Intuitive.

These words helped me survive a world that punishes my texture.

But I've also used them to dodge growth.

To protect the parts of me I didn't want to confront.

The parts that ghost people. That burn out bridges. That self-destruct before anyone else can reject me first.

There's a version of “self-love” that is seductive.

It's soft. It's safe. It whispers:

“Don't change, you're perfect as you are.”

But I know I'm not.

Does real self-acceptance doesn't mean no longer changing?

Does it mean finally being *rooted enough to grow*?

Does it means saying:

Yes, this is how I'm wired-

and I still get to choose what I build with these hands.

Yes, I feel shame-

and I don't need to let it dictate my story.

The trick is knowing when I'm telling the truth,

and when I'm just tired.

When I'm honoring my nature,

and when I'm abandoning the parts of me that want more.

Sometimes, it's hard to tell.

But I know one thing:

the moment I use my identity to stop listening-

to others, to myself-

that's when it's no longer a mirror.

It's a trap.

Chapter 37

The Gift and the Burn

ADHD ISN'T A QUIRK.

It's not the thing that makes me “spontaneous” or “creative” or “fun.”

It's the thing that keeps me from finishing what I start.

That makes the room too loud when no one's speaking.

That turns joy into obsession, and obsession into ruin.

It's missing deadlines that I *desperately* wanted to meet.

It's forgetting the thing I cared about most while chasing the thing that hijacked my brain that morning.

It's people thinking I don't care-

when really, I care so much it paralyzes me.

I can light up a room and then still forget to answer to a text for two weeks.

I can hyperfocus until the world disappears,

and then burn out so hard it takes weeks to recover.

And I've been praised for it.

Celebrated for the chaos I somehow turn into art.

But what they don't see is the price.

The relationships strained by inconsistency.

The shame that creeps in after the performance ends.

This isn't cute. It's not romantic.

It's living with a brain that won't hold still.

That floods and blanks.

That invents brilliance and then forgets where it put it.

Chapter 38

People Leave When I Don't Show Up

It's easy to say I'm misunderstood.

Harder to admit that I *disappear*.

I leave without leaving.

I answer halfway.

I nod without listening.

I say yes with no intention of following through.

Not because I don't care-God, I care too much-

but because showing up fully requires a stability I don't trust in myself.

I want to be loved for my depths, but I offer people only glimpses.

Flashes of brilliance in a storm of inconsistency.

They call me intense, magnetic, complicated.

But eventually, they stop calling.

And I tell myself it's because they couldn't handle me.

Maybe.

Or maybe they just got tired of chasing a ghost.

People leave because I made connection too difficult.

Too full of apology. Too allergic to routine.

They leave because I taught them that I would always choose the idea over the follow-through.

The possibility over the responsibility.

I've hurt people.

Not out of malice, but neglect.

I've dropped friends in the silence between replies.

I've shown up late-mentally, emotionally, physically-
and then cried when they stopped waiting.

I expect people to know how to love me through the fog.

And when they don't, I call it abandonment-

when maybe it was just consequence.

I can blame my wiring.

My ADHD. My trauma. My chaos.

All of it's true.

But truth without accountability is just another exit.

If I want people to stay,

I have to start showing up-

not as the idealized version of myself,

but as the one who forgets, fails, and still *chooses to return*.

Part Five

Chapter 39

Where the Anxiety Lives

IT'S NOT JUST in my head.

It lives in my *body*.

It starts behind my sternum-

a tightening, like my heart is being smothered in static.

A pressure that says:

Something's wrong.

Fix it.

You're in danger.

Something's wrong.

But there's no name for the danger. Just the pounding.

Just the endless alertness.

Then my gut twists.

It *folds*.

Like someone wrung it out.

Like my body's trying to protect me from a blow that's not coming.

Or maybe it already did.

Maybe I've been flinching at the memory of it for years.

The back of my neck buzzes-

a low, electric hum like I'm being watched.

Not by a person, but by the future.

By consequence.

By all the things I haven't done yet

and the ones I can't take back.

And then my gums.

They tighten.

Like they're holding in the scream my throat won't release.

Sometimes I catch myself grinding my teeth so hard it feels like I'm trying to crush my own voice.

I *wear anxiety*.

In the way I clench my fists when I sleep.

In the way I rub my jaw without noticing.

In the way my whole body leans forward-like I'm bracing for impact even in silence.

But I am tired of living like a battlefield.

Tired of being in a state of readiness for a war that only exists inside me.

And the worst part?

I've learned to function like this.

To perform while burning.

To speak calmly while detonating.

This isn't nerves.

This is a *full-body memory* of everything I've ever feared-

compressed into the moment I'm supposed to "act normal."

Chapter 40

I'm Scared the World Will Move On Without Me

THERE IS a part of me that's afraid of being forgotten.

Not in the shallow way.

I don't need every room to know my name.

But I want to matter.

I want to be missed when I'm gone.

I want to leave something behind that doesn't vanish with applause.

I built a life on impact.

Paintings. Talks. Systems.

Things that stay when I don't.

But if I'm honest,

some of that was driven by the quiet dread

that if I stop making,

stop performing,

stop producing-

the world will just... keep going.

That I'll become a story told in past tense.

A "he used to" instead of a "he is."

Sometimes I scroll through my own press.

As if to remind myself: You mattered once.

It's not pride. It's fear.

But here's what I'm starting to face-

Relevance is a moving target.

And chasing it will cost you the very presence

you once had to offer.

So I'm trying-slowly-

to let go of being remembered

and focus on being real.

I can't control legacy.

But I can control how true I am

while I'm still here.

Chapter 41

Addiction Isn't Just the Substance

ADDICTION IS whatever I use to stop feeling.

Whatever I run to when the silence gets too loud.

Whatever gives me control when the rest of my life feels like a tide I can't swim against.

I'm addicted to intensity.

To beginnings.

To chaos disguised as inspiration.

To people who burn as brightly as they disappear.

I'm addicted to fixing things that never asked to be fixed.

To working late into the night not because it's urgent, but because I'm scared of being alone with myself.

Addiction wears different masks on me:

Overcommitment.

Overachievement.

Scrolling.

Self-destruction.

"Just one more project."

"Just one more hour."

"Just one more hit of meaning."

I chase the high of productivity until my body collapses.

Then call it burnout like I didn't pour gasoline on my own fuse.

I've even used healing as an addiction-

Therapy, retreats, self-work-so I never have to sit still and actually *be* the healed version of myself.

I'm more comfortable processing than arriving.

The climb gives me purpose. The summit terrifies me.

I don't know who I am without the chase.

Without the next thing.

Without the fix.

And I hate that about myself.

But hating it has never stopped it.

Because addiction isn't about liking the thing.

It's about needing it more than you want to need yourself.

I've just learned how to mask it.

Make it look like drive.

Make it look like purpose.

But at 2:47 a.m., when no one's watching,

I know what it really is.

It's the part of me still searching for a way to escape the weight of being alive.

Chapter 42

On being wronged

THERE'S a particular kind of pain that comes from knowing you're right-
and choosing peace anyway.

I've felt the weight of injustice press down on my chest
while everyone else smiled like nothing happened.

I've been lied about.

Misunderstood.

Erased in rooms I once built.

And the worst part?

I knew I had the words.

I knew I could scorch the earth and walk away untouched.

But I didn't.

Not because I was weak.

Because I knew what repeating the pain would cost.

Sometimes I lose battles I could win

because I don't want to be another voice shouting across the wound.

I want my children to inherit something else.

So I take the hit.

I stay silent longer than I should.

I surrender-not to them, but to *grace*.

That is the hardest work I've ever done.

Not creating art.

Ending the cycle.

Chapter 43

I Learned to Apologize for Being Alive Before I Ever Asked to Be Loved

BEFORE I EVER SAID "I love you,"

I said "Sorry."

Sorry for being loud.

Sorry for crying.

Sorry for needing touch.

Sorry for existing with too many feelings and not enough filters.

I apologized for my joy, my chaos, my hunger.

Because the first time I reached for love,

I was told I was too much.

So I shrank.

So they could love me in pieces.

And every time someone said “You’re amazing,”

I waited.

For the “but.”

Because I was taught love is something you **earn**

by disappearing *just enough* to make someone comfortable.

Chapter 44

When the Mirror Turned Away

I USED to believe she could see me.

Not the version I performed, not the public mask-

but the self I didn’t know how to name.

The self before TED. Before New York. Before the crowd.

And for a while, that was enough.

But slowly, something shifted.

Not with a door slam or betrayal.

But in the everyday silences. The rehearsed routines.

The way her eyes stopped pausing on me.

It’s a strange thing-

to feel invisible in the presence of someone who once held your soul like
breath.

We were still talking. Still co-parenting.

Still moving through life like a team.

But the mirror had turned.

And I didn't know how to reflect myself anymore.

There's a grief that comes not from absence,

but from presence without recognition.

And so I did what I always do-

I made art. I overcompensated.

I grew louder, hoping she'd hear me again.

But the more I painted, the more distance I created.

Not just from her-but from myself.

I couldn't tell if I was creating or covering up.

If I was reaching for her or trying to prove I didn't need her to see me.

In the end, we broke.

Not in a single moment-

but through the quiet violence of not being seen anymore.

I've tried to love since.

Tried to be known.

But part of me is still standing in that space-

between who I was, and who I had to become

when the mirror turned away.

Chapter 45

What If She Didn't Come Back?

THERE ARE some losses you prepare for,

and some you feel in your bones long before they happen.

When my mother fell ill,

I pretended not to panic.

I made art. I showed up for work. I kept moving.

But underneath the performance, I was seven again-

the boy who used to crawl into her lap,

not because he needed comfort,

but because he needed to remember he was real.

She wasn't just my mother.

She was my first mirror.

The first person who didn't flinch at my fullness-
the contradictions, the confusion, the constant becoming.
When she was in the hospital,
hooked up to quiet machines,
I sat beside her and wondered:
If she goes... what happens to the part of me she holds?
I thought about all the things I hadn't said.
The small sacred truths:
That her softness was my first language.
That her stubborn belief in me
kept me from unraveling completely.
I watched her breathe
like each inhale was a negotiation.
And in that moment, I realized-
I had built a world on the assumption she would always be there.
I left that hospital changed.
Not just because she survived,
but because I finally saw the scale of what she'd carried-
what she still carries.
I carry it now too, in different ways.
In the way I father.

In the way I refuse to look away from pain.
In the way I keep choosing tenderness, even when the world rewards
performance.
She didn't teach me that with words.
She taught me by surviving.

Chapter 46

I Am All of Them, All at Once

THERE WERE years I tried to become singular.

To reduce myself into something understandable.

To pick one identity, one voice, one version of me that would survive.

It worked.

But it was also a kind of violence.

Because the truth is-I am not one thing.

I am the cartoonist and the mystic.

The father writing bedtime letters and the man who disappeared when things got hard.

The one who chased fame to be seen

and the one who now longs for silence.

I am the wild erotic and the sacred celibate.

The child who wanted to be loved for simply existing

and the man who keeps building things so he has a reason to be held.

There are versions of me that hate each other.

That would argue at the dinner table.

But I'm learning to let them all stay.

Not reconcile. Not blend.

Just stay.

Because maybe integration doesn't mean harmony.

Maybe it just means honesty.

To say:

Yes, I did that.

Yes, I became that.

Yes, I'm still becoming something else.

I am not consistent.

But I am *true*.

And maybe that's enough.

I used “special” to excuse the wreckage.

To dodge the stillness that might show me I’m just... human.

Not chosen.

Not doomed.

Just accountable.

Just a man trying not to vanish into his own myth.

Chapter 47

I Am Not Special

I BELIEVED I WAS DIFFERENT. Meant for something larger.

That the dysfunction was a cost of brilliance.

That if I struggled, it was because I was vibrating at a frequency too high for the world.

But the truth is less poetic.

I flake. I spiral. I disappear mid-promise.

I crave intensity and then resent the crash.

I want to be known, but I design exits into every relationship.

I dressed it all up as destiny.

I called it vision.

But sometimes it’s just avoidance.

Sometimes I destroy what I love because I don’t know how to live without turbulence.

Chapter 48

What If They Inherit My Silence?

I'M TERRIFIED my children will inherit the parts of me I worked hardest to bury.

Not my art.

Not my ambition.

But my silence.

My need to perform.

My habit of disappearing from myself when things get too loud inside.

They see me as Appa.

The one who draws. The one who once lived in New York. The one who shows up on weekends.

But what they don't see-what I've worked so hard to keep from them-is the cost of all that.

The nights I sleep with guilt curled at the foot of my bed.

The questions I dodge because the answers would break something sacred between us.

I see it most in my first born.

The way he pauses before speaking, as if scanning for permission.

The way he carries responsibility too young, too heavy.

The way he tries to hold both love and loyalty in one hand without dropping either.

It's unbearable.

Because I remember being that child.

And I know what it does-

the way it teaches you to monitor your joy,

to ration your truth,

to become the peacekeeper in a war that wasn't yours.

I write them letters.

Ones they may never read.

Ones where I say the things I can't always say aloud.

Like:

"I'm sorry the adults around you are so loud with their pain and so quiet with their healing."

Or:

"I'm trying. Even when it doesn't look like it. Especially then."

Sometimes I wonder if all I've given them is a better-edited version of my own ache.

And if they'll grow up thinking that's what love is:

a beautiful mask

over a desperate need to be understood.

But then-

one of them draws something wild.

Unedited. Untamed.

And I remember:

There's still time.

Not to be perfect.

But to be real.

And maybe that's the only inheritance that matters.

Part Six

Chapter 49

I Fall in Love with Their Potential, Not Their Pulse

I SEE SOMEONE,

and instantly imagine who they could become

I fall in love with their *next version*-

the healed one, the braver one, the one who'll finally reflect me back.

And when they stay soft, confused, still haunted-

I feel betrayed.

As if they owed me transformation just for believing in them.

I know that's not fair.

But it's what I learned.

That love is a project.

That loving someone means sculpting them into their highest self.

The truth?

I wasn't seeing them.

I was using them to love the part of me I hadn't forgiven yet.

Chapter 50

I Don't Know the Difference Between Desire and Worship

THERE ARE people I've loved

so much it felt like falling to my knees.

And not in ecstasy.

In surrender.

I called it love.

I blurred the lines between adoration and annihilation.

Made them gods

so I didn't have to admit

I was scared to be their equal.

I said: *Take all of me*

when I meant: *Don't leave me.*

I wasn't offering love.

I was offering sacrifice.

Chapter 51

The Addiction to Being Wanted

I SAY I long for silence.

But if I'm honest-deeply, violently honest-I've been addicted to being wanted.

Desired. Admired. Needed.

Not by one. By many. By *all*.

There's a kind of high I get from being the center.

Not for power. Not even for ego.

But because in those moments, I feel less disposable.

It's not just the applause.

It's the *tether*. The proof I matter.

So I chase it.

Even when I pretend I've outgrown it.

Even when I say I'm done performing.

But I still watch their eyes when I speak.

Still measure my worth in the weight of their attention.

Still get restless when the room is too quiet for too long.

Chapter 52

My Body Has Never Been Just Mine

THERE WAS a time I thought my body belonged to me.

That it was mine to explore, to express, to love.

But early on, I learned it was a site of judgment.

Of control.

Of contradiction.

I was taught to be ashamed of it-

its hunger, its confusion.

And later, I was taught to use it-

as a symbol, as a vessel, as performance.

I danced between desire and denial.

Between hiding and flaunting.

Between wanting to be held, and fearing what that would expose.

Even in love, my body often wasn't present.

I've performed pleasure.

I've withheld it.

And used sex as a way to disappear

It's only now-through art, through slowness, through breaking-
that I've started to come back to my own skin.

To feel that this body,

with all its memory, its wounds, its wanting,

might finally be allowed to belong to *me*.

And maybe that's what intimacy really is-

not the merging of bodies,

but the slow, terrifying process

of showing someone the parts you haven't yet learned to love.

Chapter 53

Body Waiting

I LIE naked under the towel. Not aroused. Not calm.

Just waiting.

Not for him.

For *something*.

The drag of his palms down my thigh makes my breath shift.

I know he's not going to touch me there.

That's what makes it unbearable.

And perfect.

And mine.

It's not about wanting *him*.

It's not even about wanting a hand job.

It's about *being close to the line*,

and feeling my body twitch toward it without shame.

It's about the heat of not-asking.

The holiness of tension without transaction.

And if he ever did it-if he ever gave in-I'd be disgusted.

Because it would mean the spell broke.

I think I want to be desired.

But maybe I just want to be *noticed by the air around me*.

Chapter 54

I Want the Boy Who's Already Lived a Thousand Lives

I'M NOT CHASING YOUTH.

I'm chasing time folded into a body

that still hasn't learned to lie to itself.

I want the kind of young man who feels ancient.

Not in years.

In eyes.

The boy who walks like he's already grieved something unnamed.

The one who holds stillness like a ritual.

The kind who makes you feel like you're being watched

and forgiven

at the same time.

I don't want innocence.

I want *earned softness*.

The kind of softness that comes after pain.

After knowing exactly how the world breaks you
and still choosing to stay fragile.

And they don't see what I see.

They don't see the boy who holds grief in his jaw
but still laughs without irony.

The one who knows how to listen
because no one listened to him when it mattered.

That's who I want.

The young man who already knows death.

Who has buried versions of himself
and still looks at me without fear.

I want that.

maybe what I've been trying to find all along is-

Someone who sees the boy in me,

without making me feel like a child.

Someone who reminds me that softness isn't weakness.

And I'll keep choosing him

over and over again-

even if the world keeps asking me to explain why.

Chapter 55

I've Always Loved the In-Betweens

LOOKING BACK, my crushes have never made sense to other people.

But they've always made sense to me.

Never the hypermasculine, chest-thumpers.

Not the hyperfeminine, manicured softness.

I've always been drawn to the *between*.

The soft boy who cried at movies.

The woman who could break your nose and then apologize with her
eyes.

I fall in love with contradiction.

With bodies that carry both sharpness and surrender.

And maybe it's always been like this because I've never fully seen myself
in one box either.

I've been strong. I've been tender.

I've been protector and prey.

And when I look at someone who exists in that same in-between space,
it doesn't confuse me.

It calms me.

Lately, I've been more open with men.

More curious. More available.

And not just sexually-but emotionally.

Because the truth is-

Women scare me.

Not because they've all hurt me,

but because the ones who did

did it with precision.

I've been loved by women in ways that felt conditional.

I've been mothered, monitored, measured.

With men, it feels simpler.

At least lately.

There's no script I'm failing to meet.

No echoes of past demands.

Just... presence.

Or maybe I'm fooling myself.

Maybe men feel safer

because I don't expect them to *see* me fully.

Maybe I give them less power to wound me.

Maybe that's just survival.

I don't know.

I'm still asking.

Still circling this part of myself like a house I built but never lived in.

But I do know this:

I want the in-between.

The and.

The softness inside the strength.

The strength inside the ache.

And I want to stop apologizing

for the parts of me that don't fit cleanly into someone else's understanding.

Because this isn't a phase.

It's a remembering.

Chapter 56

The Trouble With Seeing People's Potential

I'VE ALWAYS SEEN MORE in people than they see in themselves.

It feels like a gift-this x-ray vision for potential.

Like I'm glimpsing the future version of them:

brilliant, brave, awake.

I fall in love with that version.

Not romantically, always-but spiritually.

I cheer for them. Build altars to their becoming.

Make space they didn't ask for.

And when they don't rise?

When they can't, or won't, or simply aren't ready?

A part of me folds in.

Another part judges.

Not harshly. Quietly.

But it's still judgment.

A slow resentment wrapped in disappointment,

because they didn't become the vision I built for them.

It took me years to realize that was control, not love.

That it wasn't fair.

And now, painfully, I see that I've done it too.

But here's what I'm learning:

Love doesn't look forward.

It sits beside.

It asks, "Who are you today?"

And listens without fixing.

I want to be the kind of man

who can love what is-

not just what might be.

Chapter 57

What Love Might Look Like Now

NOT CLEAN.

Not perfect.

Not framed in soft light.

Just... real.

Love now doesn't sound like a promise.

It looks like someone asking,

"What do you need tonight?"

and me not evading.

It looks like silence that isn't punishment.

Like disagreement without withdrawal.

Like laughter that doesn't have to be clever.

Like sex that doesn't need choreography.

It's a room I'm still building.

Sharp edges.

Echoes.

Holes I used to fill with applause, performance, punishment.

But I want someone to come in anyway.

Not to fix it.

Not to curate it.

Just to sit down on the floor and say,

"I'm okay if it's not finished yet."

Love now looks like slow mornings.

Looks like being touched when I haven't earned it.

Looks like letting someone see me before I've had time to prepare the version that looks lovable.

It's about *presence*.

A kind of presence that doesn't evaporate when I stop dazzling.

I don't want someone to understand my art.

I want someone to understand why I still wake up in the middle of the night

wishing I were better at loving.

I want to be witnessed.

I want someone who sees my sharpness,

and doesn't shrink.

Someone who notices the distance I build,

and waits at the edge without judgment.

and says,

“This. This one. I’ll take him.”

Part Seven

Chapter 58

Still Becoming

IF THERE'S one thing I know now,

it's that I'm not done.

Not with healing.

Not with breaking.

Not with returning to truths I thought I'd outgrown.

I've performed.

I've disappeared.

I've been held up and thrown down.

I've loved with everything I had

and still lost people I couldn't bear to let go of.

I've been the boy drawing forbidden bodies,

the man inventing himself out of pain,
the father trying to show up even when he's falling apart.
And still-
beneath it all-
a quiet voice keeps whispering:
You're not finished.
You're not meant to be.
No clean resolution to this becoming.
Now only the practice of returning.
To the brush.
To the breath.
To the child.
To the self.
So if you're reading this-
not for answers,
but because you, too, are unraveling-
Then I hope you remember this:
You don't have to be whole to be worthy.
You don't have to be healed to be honest.
You don't have to be found to be free.

You just have to keep showing up
to the life that keeps asking for you.
Still becoming.
Still here.

Chapter 59

I'm Still a Mess—But It Doesn't Scare Me Anymore

THERE WAS a time I thought peace meant resolution.

That I'd eventually reach some clean place inside-

no noise, no regret, no contradiction.

I waited for it like a reward.

Like something I'd earn

if I just healed hard enough,

loved deeply enough,

created brilliantly enough.

But peace never came like that.

It didn't arrive in silence.

It didn't come after the perfect show,

or the right partner,

or the next reinvention.

What's happening now-

slowly, unevenly-

is different.

I haven't found peace.

But I've stopped fearing the mess.

I've stopped needing everything to add up

before I can rest.

Stopped rehearsing how to explain my pain

before I let someone see it.

I still get it wrong.

Still retreat.

Still judge.

Still want to be special.

Still want to be loved without having to bleed for it.

But I no longer punish myself

for not being done.

That's what's changed.

I don't trust the stories that promise peace as a finish line.

I trust the small moments now-

when I don't defend myself,

when I can say “I don’t know” and not withdraw.

I’m not at peace.

But I’m not at war, either.

And maybe that’s something.

Maybe that’s everything.

Chapter 60

The Sacred in the Mess

WHEN MY MOTHER ALMOST DIED, I didn’t feel spiritual.

I felt afraid.

Ungripped.

Like the scaffolding I’d built my life on-ambition, reinvention, art-wasn’t enough.

But something unexpected happened in the silence that followed.

Not enlightenment. Not peace.

I started to see the sacred in places I used to rush past.

The smudge on my studio wall.

The rhythm of breath when my daughter sleeps.

The weight of a brush before it touches canvas.

Transcendence, I realized, isn’t a higher state.

It's a deeper one.

It's not about leaving the body.

It's about *re-entering it fully*.

It's the moment I cried after painting over a canvas I'd worked on for months-

not because it was ruined,

but because I was finally honest enough to let go of what wasn't true.

It's the moment I let my son cry without fixing it,

just held him,

and felt something pass between us that had no name,

only recognition.

It's the moment I touched my partner's back in silence,

and the whole room felt like a cathedral.

For so long, I thought transcendence was about becoming more.

But maybe it's about becoming **fully here**.

In the mess.

In the ache.

In the unfinished conversation.

In the beauty that doesn't need to be understood to be real.

And maybe that's what art is-

A quiet attempt to touch something vast

by finally showing up for what's small.

Chapter 61

What If I'm Just Pretending Again?

WHAT IF ALL of this-

the raw honesty, the longing, the vulnerability-

is just another costume?

A smarter one.

A quieter one.

But still a performance.

What if I've just learned how to say the right kind of real things

so people think I'm *brave* instead of *desperate*?

What if I've figured out how to name the ache

but not feel it?

What if I've built a beautiful, bruised vocabulary

just to avoid being actually touched?

Because I know how to write pain that sounds earned.

I know how to confess in a way that gets praise.

I know how to say "I'm scared"

in a way that still keeps control.

But do I ever stop?

Do I ever actually let someone in?

Or am I just staging the vulnerability

so no one notices

that I never stay past the climax?

Maybe I've gotten so good at describing the wound

that I forgot how to bleed.

And if that's true-

if I'm still pretending,

even now, even here-

then I have to ask:

what am I so afraid would happen

if I finally stopped?

If I actually let it be real,

without the elegance,

without the edge,

without the script?

Would I lose everyone?

Or would I finally

find out

what stays

when there's nothing left

to perform?

Chapter 62

Teaching Myself How Not to Perform

I'VE BEEN PERFORMING for so long, I didn't know I was doing it.

It's in how I smile at the right time.

How I give just enough vulnerability to seem open-
without ever actually opening.

Performance is my default.

So now I have to teach myself something new-

how to *stay* when I'm not impressive.

How to *breathe* when the room isn't clapping.

How to *exist* without the need for applause or control.

Here's what I'm trying:

Step one:

Notice the moment I reach for charm instead of truth.

Catch it.

Don't punish it.

Just name it: *That was a performance.*

Step two:

Let silence last longer than it's comfortable.

Resist the urge to fill it with cleverness.

Sit in it. Let it stretch. Let it say what I won't.

Step three:

Speak slower.

Not like I'm teaching.

Not like I'm seducing.

Just like I'm *here*.

Step four:

Answer questions without editing.

Not the polished version.

Not the wise one.

The one I'd only say to myself.

Step five:

Watch how I try to become what they want.

Feel it in my body-

the tightening, the adjusting, the scan for approval.

And stop.

Breathe.

Be ordinary for a minute.

Risk being forgettable.

Step six:

When I want to disappear after being honest-

don't.

Stay.

Watch what happens when I don't explain myself away.

And maybe the most important-

Step seven:

Forgive myself when I fuck it up.

When I perform anyway.

When I backslide.

When I fall into old grooves like they're home.

Because they were.

For a long time.

But I'm building something new now.

And it doesn't need a stage.

Just a room.

A body.

A voice I don't dress up anymore.

Even if no one claps.

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